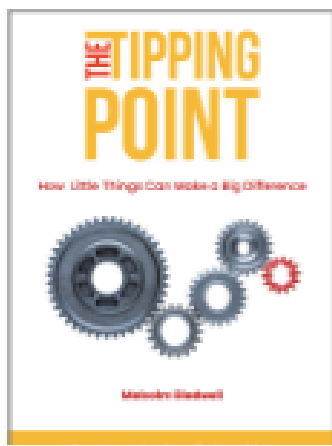




THE TIPPING POINT

HOW LITTLE THINGS CAN MAKE
A BIG DIFFERENCE

By Malcolm Gladwell

The Big "So What" ???

The book seeks "to answer two simple questions.... **Why is it that some ideas or behaviour or products start epidemics and others don't? What can we do to deliberately start and control positive epidemics of our own?**"

Introduction



Gladwell starts off by explaining the concept of "the tipping point" with two stories. **It is about reaching the boiling point, or critical mass, where everything tips and spreads like a virus.** The book illustrates this concept in depth with various examples, starting with

how Hush Puppies (an aging shoe line at that time) became an elite fashion statement in less than two years, followed by how the high crime rate in New York City suddenly dropped after many years.

The Three Rules of Epidemics

What causes something to tip and spread like an epidemic? Gladwell identifies three prerequisites or "rules of epidemics":

- **The Law of the Few** : A tiny percentage of people are accountable for building huge initial momentum because of their special social gifts. These are the Mavens, the Connectors and the Salesmen.
- **The Stickiness Factor** : There is a simple way to package information such that it is irresistible and memorable - i.e. it "sticks".

KEY QUOTES

The Tipping Point

"The name given to that one dramatic moment in an epidemic when everything can change all at once is the Tipping Point."

- **The Power of Context** : Human beings are a lot more sensitive to their environment than they seem. By changing the context and managing their social groups, you can shape their behaviours.

1 The Law of the Few

Many trends are started by the small groups of people – **Mavens, Connectors and Salesmen**. Gladwell provides several detailed examples and past events that show how to identify each of these, and how they help to tip epidemics.



Mavens (the Data Banks): Mavens seem to know everything. They have the inside scoop on the marketplace and know things that we don't. Besides accumulating knowledge, they have a compulsion to share their knowledge and help others make informed decisions. In short, **"mavens are really information brokers, sharing and trading what they know"**.



Connectors (the Social Glue): Connectors are those who seem to know everyone. They have an "ability to span many different worlds (due to) some combination of curiosity, self-confidence, sociability and energy". **Because they have a foot in so many realms, they essentially bring them together.**



Salesmen (the Persuaders): Salesmen are those who seem to effortlessly induce others' buying decisions and behaviours. They have innate skills and charisma that make them so persuasive. **"It's energy. It's enthusiasm. It's charm. It's likeability. It's all of those things and yet something more."**

KEY QUOTES

Law of the Few

"The success of any kind of social epidemic is heavily dependent on the involvement of people with a particular and rare set of social gifts...I call them Connectors, Mavens, and Salesmen."

"Mavens are data banks. They provide the message. Connectors are social glue: they spread it. Salesmen (have) the skills to persuade us when we are unconvinced of what we are hearing."

Reaching out to the marketplace through influencers may seem obvious today, but this was definitely a novel idea at the time Gladwell wrote the book. It still an important reminder of where we should focus our resources when launching a word-of-mouth campaign.



2 The Stickiness Factor

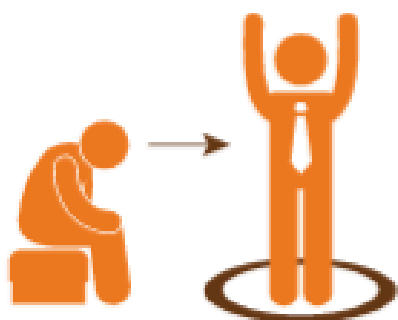
Stickiness means that a message leaves such a deep impression that it's stuck in your head. There are many ways to make something stick, be it stories, audience participation or repetition. The tough part is to find the right stickiness factor for the target audience.

Gladwell goes into details of how two popular children's TV shows, Sesame Street and Blue's Clues, managed to capture children's attention and became major successes. He shows examples of how success often hinges on small details (such as placements and sequencing) rather than major changes (such as a revamp of the content).



3 The Power of Context

There are 2 parts to understanding and applying the Power of Context



a. Change the Context to Change Behaviours:

Gladwell points out that human character isn't as stable or fixed as we may think. Our characters are a loose combination of habits, interests and tendencies which vary depending on

KEY QUOTES

The Stickiness Factor

"There is a simple way to package information that, under the right circumstances, can make it irresistible. All you have to do is find it."

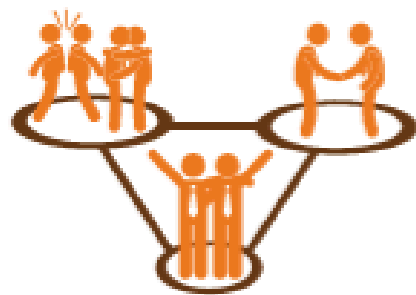
The Power of Context

"Human beings are a lot more sensitive to their environment than they may seem... an epidemic can be reversed, can be tipped, by tinkering with the smallest details of the immediate environment."

circumstances the contexts we're in. When the context or immediate details of our situation are changed, the definition of acceptable behaviour (and consequently our actual behaviours) will change too.

Gladwell gives several examples of how people may behave seemingly out of character, including committing crime, when they are placed in different environments. In short, your heart-felt convictions and actual thoughts are less important in determining your actions and behaviors than your immediate context.

Gladwell also examines the "Broken Window Theory," which suggests that broken windows in a neighborhood will lead to higher violent crime rates. Based on the Power of Context, to reduce the crime rate, we should fix the windows rather than arrest people for crime.



b. Rule of 150

Gladwell moves next into the concept of social channel capacity. He suggests that we

can increase our chances of tipping epidemics simply by manipulating the size of groups. The best way to manage a group of people is to keep the group sizes within 150 people. When a group is too big, people don't have enough shared memories, nor are they close enough for peer pressure to effectively kick in. Use organized mechanisms to facilitate the movement of new ideas and information within and between the groups, so it's easier for social influences to tip things over.

This important rule gives us fresh lenses to understand the dynamics of social media and professional networks like LinkedIn, Facebook and Twitter.

Applying the Rules of Epidemic



Focus your resources on the few. Starting an epidemic requires resources. Focus them where it matters – on the Connectors,

KEY QUOTES

"Keeping things under 150 just seems to be the best and most efficient way to manage a group of people... If you get too large, you don't have enough work in common. You don't have enough things in common".

Mavens and Salesmen, as they will determine if successfully spark an epidemic to begin with. Don't waste your resources elsewhere; concentrate them fully on those 3 groups.



Find your Stickiness Factor. Don't rely on your intuition or gut-feel of what will work. Test your theories on what messages will stick, before you roll them out on a large scale. Notably, small details matter as much as, if not more than, big changes. Pilot testing, Beta testing and A-B testing etc. are all ways to identify your Stickiness Factor before a full launch.



Manage contexts to shape behaviour. First, consider the environment, circumstances and conditions when choosing the timing and location of your messages. Second, keep group sizes to under 150 and use systems and processes to keep the community tightly connected.

Other Useful Details in the Book to Look Out For

Gladwell builds a strong case for the 3 rules of epidemics, with a wide range of examples and case studies to help us understand how epidemics work (and why they fail). Notably, his examples and illustrations cover a variety of industries and scenarios including:

- Retail brands such as shoe companies Hush Puppies and Airwalk, and innovation clothing company Gore
- Politics, crime rates, teen suicide and smoking trends, including the reversal of negative epidemics
- Real-life examples of connectors, mavens and salesmen: who they are, what makes them different, and how they tip epidemics
- Children and education programs, including Sesame Street, Blue's Clues and medical programs
- Books and communities including Divine Secrets of the Ya Ya Sisterhood and the Hutterite Methodist community

KEY QUOTES

Starting an Epidemic

"Merely by manipulating the size of a group, we can dramatically improve its receptivity to new ideas.

By tinkering with the presentation of information, we can significantly improve its stickiness. Simply by finding and reaching those few special people who hold so much social power, we can shape the course of social epidemics."